both said they could not support the legislation before the full Knesset. Four other ministers from Lapid's party followed him out the door, and Israel headed for early elections. "We had no choice but to join the finance minister and the justice minister, because there is no point in a belligerent government, a government without a future, without hope," said Shai Piron, the education minister.

"Faith unites us"

Sitting on the sidelines, and watching all of this with interest, were Israel's two ultra-Orthodox parties. They had just spent two long years outside the government, their first stint in the opposition since the 1990s. It was a difficult time: as mentioned earlier, the Knesset passed a 2014 law that would have required some *haredi* men to perform army service; those who refused would face jail time like their non-Orthodox compatriots. It also slashed the state stipends paid to young men studying in *yeshivot*. The community blamed much of this on Lapid, and shortly after the election it vowed never to sit in a coalition with him. (They wouldn't have to. Netanyahu would go with his base, forming a right/religious coalition, while Lapid went to the opposition, and the ultra-Orthodox quickly set to work undoing the accomplishments of the past government.)

The *haredim* (literally, those who "tremble" at God's word) have always had a complicated relationship with Zionism. In the late nineteenth century, many of Europe's leading rabbis were overtly anti-Zionist, because they believed that only divine intervention and not human endeavor should recreate a Jewish state in Palestine. Some regarded Zionism as a false messianic movement—a sort of cult. "The Torah obliges us, further, to allow our longing for the far-off land to express itself only in mourning, in wishing and hoping; and only through the honest fulfillment of all Jewish duties to await the realization of this hope. But it forbids us to strive for the reunion or possession of the land by any but spiritual means," wrote Samson Raphael Hirsch of Germany.

Aside from the scriptural problems, many ultra-Orthodox leaders were also deeply skeptical about what form the state would take. The early Zionist leaders, the descendants of the Jewish enlightenment, were secular men. Theodor Herzl, Max Nordau, Chaim Weizmann, even Ze'ev Jabotinsky, the founder of the Revisionist school—all fell somewhere